

Is or Are? You Might Be Surprised

In this lesson, we're going to look at how to properly use 'is' and 'are'. These short words might seem easy, but they have some tricky secrets that trip up even the most experienced English speakers. We'll go through examples, and I'll give you some tips so you always get it right. Don't forget to take the quiz at the end to see how much you've learnt!

The verb 'to be'

So, **is** or **are**?

The simplest explanation of these words is that they are both present simple forms of the verb **to be**.

he/she/it	is
you/we/they	are

If the noun in a sentence is singular, use **is**.

- The dog is on the sofa.

If the noun in a sentence is plural, use **are**.

- The dogs are in the garden.

Collective Nouns

With collective nouns (nouns that can refer to groups of people or things), it gets a bit more complicated.

In British English, you can usually use **is** or **are** with collective nouns, depending on how you think of the group. If you think of them as many individuals, use **are**.



If you think of the group as one entity or idea, use **is**. Basically, in British English, you can't really go wrong whether you use 'is' or 'are'.

- **The government are working on new policies.** (In this case, I'm thinking of each individual member.)
- **Our team is playing well today.** (In this case, I'm thinking about the team as a collective force!)

Collective nouns, such as 'government' and 'team', can be used with a singular or plural verb in British English, although '**are**' is used more frequently.

In American English, it is much more common to use the singular form '**is**'.

- **The government is working on new policies.**
- **Our team is playing well today.**

There are some exceptions to this rule, though! Always use '**are**' after the police in British and American English.

- **The police are investigating a serious crime.**

And when collective nouns are followed by another plural noun, we always use are.

- **My family are farmers.**
- **The committee are artists.**

Confusing Sentences!

English learners can also sometimes get confused by nouns that end in **-s** but are followed by a singular verb. These are often **diseases** or **school subjects**, like measles and mumps, physics and maths.

- **Measles is a nasty disease!**
- **Maths is pretty tricky!**



Compound Subjects

Continuing with our confusing sentences, I want to touch on compound subjects. This is when a sentence has more than one noun or pronoun as the subject. When these nouns are joined by 'and', they are followed by '**are**'.

- Rita and Ross are living in Kent at the moment.

However, if the subjects are joined by 'or', the verb **to be** must match the last subject.

- Rita or Ross is working from home — I can't remember who.
- The Joneses or the Smiths are my closest neighbours.

There is/There are

Now I want to look at 'there is' and 'there are'. Again, it seems simple:

There is + singular/uncountable noun

There are + plural noun

- There is a cat sitting under my car.
- There is some sugar in the cupboard.
- There are four Golden Retrievers in the park.

We often use contractions with '**There is**' - '**There's**'.

When you have a list of things beginning with 'There', use '**is**' if the **first thing in the list is singular** and '**are**' if the **first thing in the list is plural**. This is the rule according to most modern coursebooks and common usage.

- There are apples, pears and a huge pumpkin for sale here.
- There is a fast-food place and two sandwich shops over there.



In **informal speech**, we often use 'There is' before plural nouns. Don't do this in an exam or in formal writing, but be aware that it is common.

- There's a lot of people coming tonight.
- There's five students waiting to talk to the teacher.

Body and One

After **indefinite pronouns** like 'everybody/everyone' or 'anybody/anyone', you should use 'is'.

- Everybody is going to help pack up the house.
- Is anyone hungry yet?

Either/Neither

Now I want to look at 'either' and 'neither'. Generally, when used as determiners, either and neither should be **followed by a singular noun** and then by 'is'.

- Either restaurant is fine — just make up your mind.
- Neither team is playing very well.

Either/or and **neither/nor** can be **followed by singular or plural nouns**. Use 'is' when the subjects are singular. When the subjects are plural, use 'are'.

- Neither Diego nor Alfonso is happy when it's hot outside.
- Either Gran or Grandpa is coming to watch the school play.
- Neither the cakes nor the biscuits are very tasty.

In informal language, especially in British English, you will hear some people use 'are' with singular subjects.

- Neither my mum nor my dad are coming to watch the school play.

Don't do this in an exam or a formal context!



'Either of' and 'neither of' can be followed by a **plural noun (or pronoun)** and a **singular** or **plural verb**. A plural verb is generally considered more informal.

- **Either of my parents is/are available to pick us up.**
- **Neither of them is/are capable of fixing the fault.**
- **Neither of the referees is/are very good at their job.**

Sentences from Video Quiz

1. Physics is a fascinating subject, but unfortunately, I had a bad teacher.

- Although it ends with the letter 's', 'physics' is an uncountable noun.

2. The cats and dogs in the neighbourhood are always playful and friendly with each other.

- The subject of the sentence is two nouns joined by 'and', so we use 'are'.

3. Either day is fine for me, be it Saturday or Sunday.

- 'Either' is followed by a singular noun 'day', so we use the singular verb 'is'.

4. My family is/are planning on coming to stay with me next weekend.

is/are - 

is - 

- 'Family' is a collective noun which can be used with a singular or plural verb.

5. There are various spices, herbs and a selection of exotic teas at the local bazaar.

- The first noun in the list is plural, so a plural verb is used.

QUIZ!

1. Choose the correct 'be' verb in the sentence based on British English.

The team [is/are] playing in the championship tomorrow.

Answer: _____

2. Choose the correct 'be' verb.

The book on the table [is/are] very interesting.

Answer: _____

3. Complete the sentence with the correct 'be' verb.

The apples in the basket [is/are] ripe and ready to eat.

Answer: _____

4. Choose the correct 'be' verb.

The children [is/are] students.

Answer: _____

5. Choose the correct 'be' verb.

Physics [is/are] my favourite subject at school.

Answer: _____

6. Choose the correct 'be' verb.

The cat and the dog [is/are] sleeping on the sofa.

Answer: [is/are]

7. Choose the correct 'be' verb and complete the sentence.

_____ [is/are] three books and a pen on the desk.

Answer: _____

8. Choose the correct 'be' verb.

Neither of the options [is/are] suitable for our project.

Answer: _____

The End!